proceeding on leave at Tezpur, 9 Punjab was pushed into the Nam Ka Chu Valley from its defensive position at Tawang, 1/9 GR who had been relieved by 9 Punjab were told to retrace their steps and 2 Rajput were told to get off the train at Missamari to strengthen the Kameng Frontier Division. With the self-imposed clock now ticking ‘to throw the Chinese out’, it was again Kaul who was fine with being ‘demoted’ from CGS to a corps commander and rushed forward to conduct the battle. One would think that in Nehru’s army, there was just the one man!

What would have happened had the pickets established as a part of the Forward Policy been better armed and capable of fighting a sustained short defensive war? That question, of course, can never be answered, especially since Kaul almost single-handedly ensured that the men who had extended the line with an almost superhuman effort, simply did not have the means to fight!

Indians would do well to remember that after Kaul had completely botched the army’s operational ability in NEFA, he created a similar situation in Assam. The evacuation of Tezpur and the withdrawal of Indian troops by the Kaul-Sen duo from the North Bank was nothing short of an act of panic, especially since the Chinese had at that stage not progressed beyond Chaku and had certainly not entered the foothills. It was Mullik who told the Indian Army that if its commanders were not going to fight, he would do so using State Armed Police, if necessary.

WHERE WERE THE BOYS IN BLUE?

Having failed to read Chinese intent and having created a situation where it was believed by all in high command that the Chinese would react militarily, Mullik’s inputs on the use of the IAF as an offensive weapon are even more bewildering. In March 1960, intelligence reports that were with Eastern Command in Lucknow had indicated that the Chinese had constructed a group of airfields north of Lhasa in the region of Yanpachen. This was the main air base in Tibet that could handle the heaviest bombers then in service with the Chinese Air Force (PLAAF). Additional airstrips capable of taking jet fighters had been constructed in and around Rudok, Gartok, Tingri, Shigatse, Gyantse and Tse-la. A number of advance landing grounds from where twin-engine transport aircraft had been reported were Tradom, Khamba Dzong, Tsona Dzong, Lhuntse Dzong, Tithong and Drowagompa. The exact strength of the PLAAF was not known, but during